prosecution for voicing dissent. They seized the moment, and especially in many of the states that the Yatra covered, organized a wide variety of groups—of intellectuals, activists, handloom workers, cultivators, fisherfolk, students, healthcare workers, women and the specially abled—to join the Yatra and, where possible, discuss their concerns with Rahul Gandhi by either joining him in his inner cordon during the walk or during the daily meetings he had with different groups during lunch break.

The Congress party, too, felt the powerful impact of the Yatra. It activated the cadre, particularly the youth, who were enthused by having something to do, which was different from fighting elections. State-level leaders were also energized, and it even encouraged factional and individual rivalries to be forgotten to enable a united effort to make the Yatra a success. In Karnataka, for example, one could not miss rivals Siddaramaiah and D.K. Shivakumar walking side by side with Rahul Gandhi. One wonders if it might have contributed to their working together in the forthcoming elections and after the victory and formation of a Congress government! Is it entirely fortuitous that the Congress won both elections held after the BJY, in Himachal Pradesh and in Karnataka?

And now for Rahul Gandhi himself. What did the Yatra do for him? Of course, he would be the best judge of that, but some things looked obvious to an observer. Though he had been in public life for many years, probably his interaction was more with party workers and leaders, and not so much with the Indian masses. His security imperatives would have been another constraint. When political leaders go for election campaigns, they don’t actually meet people—they only see them from a distance from the stage or from atop a truck or a van. Door-to-door campaigning is done by the cadre. The BJY probably gave Rahul Gandhi the first extended opportunity to meet ordinary people first-hand, talk to them, hold their hands and feel their emotions. Day by day, as he walked and felt their warmth and pain and happiness and sorrow, he grew visibly more comfortable, less self-conscious, more confident and more instinctive in how he interacted with them. Ignoring the low-level jibes from the usual sources, he spontaneously walked hand in hand with young girls and women, picked up babies and